

and female. Surely, we are not thrown into the world but bring with every new birth—male and female—exciting beginnings and perspectives to develop intimate relationships with our mothers, our families, our friends, our pluralistic society, our variegated cosmos, and our Singular Divine.

The Body of Plenitude and Jouissance

The body of the Transcendent is the body of plenitude and *jouissance*. It is drunk by the Khalsa: the sapiential ingredients of the verses are sipped by the initiates, they are tasted, and they are savored. Altogether it is a very oral activity, something akin to Hélène Cixous's venture, "I was eating the texts, I was sucking, licking, kissing them, I am the innumerable child of their multitudes. . . ." ³⁷ By drinking *amrit* prepared in and with the sight and sound and touch of semiotic poetry, the Khalsa is born, and is thereafter daily nurtured and sustained by *her*. So not only are the verses the first sheaths and the first membranes that create the Khalsa, but they are also the nutrients that are physically taken inside the body and become a part of the bloodstream of the newborn members, and continue to feed them throughout their lives and that of their future generations. The hymns of the Khalsa are none other than Cixous's omnipotent mother figure, who is powerful and generous, a dispenser of life, love, and plenitude.

Semiotic *bani* is the vital link in Sikh genealogy. Her dynamic womb reproduces the drinking of *amrit* by Guru Nanak in the River Bein, and pushes the primal Sikh experience into the future. When the fifth guru compiled the poetry of his predecessors, it was his way of giving a concrete form to their very sensuous experience that would nurture the Sikh community forever. Guru Arjan did not construct theological treatises or list ethical injunctions for his Sikhs: he gave them a body of literature that he wanted them to eat (*khavai*) and savor (*bhunchai*). In his epilogue to the Granth, he says, "[T]hey who eat, they who savor, are liberated." Guru Arjan here uses the analogy of a platter. The Guru Granth is a *thal* (large metal dish) on which lie truth, contentment, and contemplation. The epistemological value of these dishes is not intellectually conceived or logically argued, it is swallowed and digested by the body. The *thal* is antithetical to male episteme, which rests on nonmaterial ideas and formless essence, and with the *thal* enjoyment of the text becomes paramount. Savoring the words is the quintessential practice for the Sikh community. For the compiler and editor, the textuality of the Guru Granth lies in its physical sensuality and not in some rigid symbolic order. Clearly, the fifth guru envisioned poetry as the body of plenitude and *jouissance*, a body that is both eaten and savored. The medieval Indian male Guru and contemporary European feminist secularists voice an

intimate relationship with their texts, and in the sacred verses of the Khalsa we can recover the multiple and endless *jouissance* that Irigaray and Cixous unabashedly write about.

The identity of knowledge and food lodged in the epilogue of the Guru Granth is prefigured in Guru Nanak's Jap, the opening hymn of the Granth: "[K]nowledge is the banquet, compassion the hostess" (Jap, stanza 29). Knowledge is a delectable banquet. This sumptuous array of dishes indicated by Guru Nanak is specified by Guru Arjan as truth, contentment, and contemplation.

We find yet another intriguing resemblance, this time between Guru Nanak's *bhandarani* (hostess) and Guru Gobind Singh's *kirpan* (sword). The features, personality, and proclivities of the hostess who distributes the food of knowledge in the Jap hymn reemerge in the Khalsa symbol of the *kirpan*. The physiognomy in each case is rooted in the symbiosis of knowledge and compassion, for both resources offer knowledge (*gian*), and both are full of compassion (*daia*). Compassion (*daia*) is actually the name of Nanak's *bhandarani*, and this virtue is shared by Guru Gobind Singh's *kirpan* (since *kirpa* means "compassion"). The figure of Nanak's "hostess" is incorporated in Sikh practice by the "sword." She is recalled in the daily hymns to guide us through our lives. She is the one who possesses the mystical recipe and prepares *amrit*. She is the one who gives final touches to Karahprashad, the Sikh sacrament, before it is distributed in the congregation.

Sadly, however, malestream interpretations dismiss her image from the guru's verse, and the male hands that prepare *amrit* and distribute Karahprashad in public worship keep *her* concealed and controlled. The trend to crush, conceal, and control the female person continues in Sikh homes and in the wider community. Mothers, daughters, and sisters who prepare food day and night are relegated to a low status and usually circumscribed to the private sphere of the home; mothers, daughters, and sisters who selflessly serve meals to their families are severed from links with wisdom and knowledge. Sikh *bani* and *bana* lyrically exhort us to acknowledge the wise and compassionate female agent in the vision of the gurus, and have her join us in both our public and private lives. Food and knowledge, body and mind, are not binaries; we receive them both from *her*. We must relearn to hear her voice, see her viewpoint, and recognize her hands as they constantly feed us with knowledge served in a variety of dishes.

The image of the hostess from the Jap shifts our sense of *gian*, or knowledge, from an isolated activity in cubbyholes within the walls of academia to the elemental processes of eating and living in the "feminine" space of the home. Indeed, *bani* absorbs abstract thought into the folds of the body. But this individual process branches out, to use Kristeva's analogy, "like a bridge between singularity and ethics."³⁸ As personified by the *bhandarani*, the expe-

rience of something so inward as tasting and digesting is shared with others. Nanak's *bhandarani*, or hostess, in the Sikh imaginary is engaged in sharing and distributing knowledge and does not place herself above her students. She draws us into kinship with fellow beings, and informs us that the mean-ing of *sangat*, the Sikh congregation, is essentially a relationship with others so that we can partake together of the delectable platter containing the dishes of truth, knowledge, and contentment. Fed by her, we extend our-selves to our families and to our human community. Knowledge is not the Father's discourse; it is not an end in itself. Knowledge is reaching out actively to help the underprivileged, the deprived, and the violated. Guru Nanak distinctly pronounces, "[K]nowledge and reflection are philanthropic deeds performed for others" (GG, 356). Knowledge for the Sikh gurus con-sists in *herethics*, a relational and dialogic *practice* that is not a philosophizing about *his* moral principles and mere abstractions.

The female conception of knowledge actually pervades the holy book. Guru Nanak identifies mother with wisdom: "[M]other is wisdom" (GG, 151); which is later repeated by his successors (172, 1397). She is even regarded as the sister-in-law who is "the most admirable member of her entire family," because "she guides her brothers-in-law, both younger and older" (371). Women in the Guru Granth are not just figures of speech. They are vital subjects who are accorded a high status in the daily course of life.

The female is quintessential to Sikh epistemology, and as I discussed in my earlier work, she is beauty, clarity, and revelation; she is the sister with eyes that see through the Formless.³⁹ What I missed out then were the scrip-tural reminders of our intellectual development in the mother's body. Kristeva's semiotic lens has helped me see through their beauty and import. To begin with, the Sikh gurus declare that the human body is precious. But it is in the mother's womb, as Guru Arjan says, "that we acquire all recogni-tion of relationships with mother, father, brother, friend" (GG, 1387). Revealing the affinity between the male Sikh gurus and modern secular fem-inists, *bani* inspires us to retreat to those initial moments and relearn the primal relationships we experienced in her oceanic womb, and from which we are now split and dichotomized. Our return would not constitute an act of regression, as our phallocentric psychoanalysts may speculate, but a real progression toward new forms of subjectivity and new avenues for discover-ing our human potential.

Food is a biological necessity, keeping us all from shriveling up and dying. So is knowledge. By equating it with food, the Sikh gurus make knowledge essential for all of us—not just for Plato's philosopher-king or the Brahmins of Vedic India. The cognitive and digestive activities are not relegated to either male or female domains, nor set apart from other activities. Knowledge is eaten, and just like food, it is necessary for our growth and fulfillment, for our

being and becoming. Eating is a most creative act: we take something from the external world and turn it into ourselves! A tiny morsel makes a circuit in us, and through the bloodstream becomes a cell, a muscle, a neuron, a thought, an emotion, an embrace. The poets of the Guru Granth repeatedly wish that the Divine be remembered in every “morsel of food” (GG, 961), making our alimentary canals elementary to our spiritual progress. Keeping with the Granthian tract, the tenth guru extols the Transcendent as “the food of foods,” “the drink of drinks” (Jaap, verse 187). He meditates on the One as “the elixir of elixirs”: *amritamrit hain* (verse 177); *amritesvar hain* (verse 179); *amritamrit hain* (verse 179); *amritamrit hain* (verse 180). The Transcendent is to be fully absorbed and assimilated into every part of our bodies. The hymns of the Khalsa incite us to free ourselves from the surveillance cameras of our culture, which coerce women to hate their bodies and the food they take in. If fully digested, semiotic *bani* could serve as an anti-dote to our modern epidemics of bulimia and anorexia nervosa. Remembering Guru Gobind Singh celebrate the Divine as food and drink, our daily meals become means of enjoying that One in each cell of our body. How could we then possibly abuse our bodies, our divine cells and selves, or abuse others in any form? Contemplation of truth does not pull us away from the ordinary functions of our life; as elemental and sumptuous as eating and drinking, it only makes us aware that every bite on our plate has a transcendent value.

Guru Nanak provides a cosmic setting for the platter image (*thal*) that Guru Arjan used in his epilogue to the Granth. In Hinduism the *thal* is used for *arati*, the daily ceremony performed at home and in temples. With lamps, incense, flowers and fruits placed on the *thal*, Hindus encircle their beloved deities. In Guru Nanak’s semiotics, this beautiful ritual performed by Hindu worshippers is choreographed by our cosmos. In his hymn *Arati*, which is recited by Sikhs every evening, the spacious and ethereal skies become the metallic platter (*thal*) on which the sun, moon, and twinkling stars are set to perform *arati* around the Infinite One! Unconstrained by patriarchal either-or logic, the Sikh gurus connect a human mode of worship with that of nature, just as they connect the food on our tables with the Guru Granth, and the dishes from our kitchen with the distant skies that constantly illuminate our lives.

Since *bani* erupts through fixed and constricted categories, patriarchal discourse finds *her* problematic. Objective historians convert her dynamic womb into a concrete ground on which they try to erect their rational constructs. In the quick dynamic motion of the verses from which can burst forth a multitude of spiritually erotic emotions, they search in vain for structure and syntax. Cixous incisively refers to syntax as “that famous thread” “which acts for men as a surrogate umbilical cord,” but which drains and divides the

maternal fluidity and sustenance.⁴⁰ *Bani* delivers the profusion of meanings in the languages of the mother tongue that Kristeva conceives—"A woman's body, with its thousand and one thresholds of ardor—once, by smashing yokes and censors, she lets it articulate the profusion of meanings that run through it in every direction—will make the old single-grooved mother tongue reverberate with more than one language."⁴¹

But seeking control over the mother's continuum, the father's syntax breaks it into subject and object, past and future, verb and adjective. The scrutiny and control that patriarchs exert on the bodies of women is exerted on the generative powers of timeless *bani*. Instead of savoring her beauty and wisdom, Western scholars have criticized her for being "incoherent," "dark," and "perplexing."⁴² Erudite discourses are unable to get in touch with the palpable and fluid female puissance that procreates the Khalsa. How can they impose the "father's famous thread" on the semiotic pulsations of *bani*? Nanak had rejected outright the infliction of any such censorship on his body. "Censor the body and you censor breath and speech at the same time," remarks Cixous.⁴³

Actually, like our bodies getting rid of invasive substances, semiotic *bani* rejects symbolic constructs. Many passages in the Guru Granth denounce scholarly volumes, grammars, and astrological texts that presume knowledge of our past and future.⁴⁴ The very first stanza of Guru Nanak's Jap opens with "Thought cannot think, nor can a million thoughts. . . . Though a thousand mental feats become a million, not one can go with us" (stanza 1). The morning hymn repeatedly flushes out the mastery of patriarchal thought: "No paper, pen or scribe nor any philosophizing help to realize . . ." (stanza 12). In a lengthy passage, Guru Nanak acknowledges scholars and divinities from many religious traditions expounding on divine greatness. Nevertheless, symbolic language is incapable of articulating the greatness of That One, for "That babblers who presumes to say is marked as the fool of fools" (26). The Jap, Jaap, and Swayyais overlap one another in their dislike for scholarly discourses. Guru Nanak claims, "[W]hen it comes to discourse, many speak out, each outdoing the other" (Jap, stanza 21), and Guru Gobind Singh rejoins, "None of the Shastras can fathom It" (Jaap, verse 86). The tenth guru retains Guru Nanak's resistance to erudition and scholarship, and his Swayyais also contain a harsh criticism of paternal presumptions and pedagogies. Without the fluidity of love, "Study of Vedas, Puranas, Kateb and Quran, of all scriptures from all times and places . . . go to naught" (Swayyais, 4), says Guru Gobind Singh categorically.

Now, the semiotic *bani* of the Khalsa does not reject world scriptures; it simply cannot bear the Father's pontificating answers, proofs, and mastery. In fact, the Guru Granth is a wonderful Body palpably holding together the verses of the Sikh gurus, Hindu *bhaktas*, and Muslim Sufis. The 1,430 pages

speak the same language of love, and enfold us in our human kinship. In the mother's womb, said Kabir, there is no name or caste, and so maternal *bani* makes no distinction either between Hindu, Muslim, and Sikh, or between weavers, tanners, and scholars. In this maternal space all differences are abolished. The infinite species coming from the same matrix speak in the same language: "[S]ome utter Ram, some Khuda" (GG, 885). Similarly, in chapter 1 we heard Guru Gobind Singh celebrate the singular Divine One for speaking "the four Vedas, the Qur'an, and the Puranas" (BN, 1:24). In his Akal Ustat as well, Guru Gobind Singh emphatically extols "the same One as the Puran and the Qur'an" (verse 86). Ultimately, the Hindu and Muslim scriptures, one in Sanskrit and the other in Arabic, share the same Author, the same Voice. For the Sikh gurus, the One Source transcends all conceptual constructs. Guru Arjan, who compiled into the Granth the utterances of the Sikh gurus along with those of Hindu and Muslim saints, declares our common vocal expression: "Vedas, Puranas, Simritis, and saints, utter this *bani* in their tongue" (GG, 1227). Hindus, Muslims, and saints of other different religious traditions speak in countless dialects our universal mother language. Guru Nanak even praises the tiny sparrow who joyfully calls *khudai khudai* for her divine beloved (1286). What is deeply felt comes out spontaneously and naturally in the mother's musical tongue, and that refuses to submit to paternal control and scrutiny. The semiotic fluids of the Khalsa's poetry wash out symbolic infections of mental feats, intellectual divisions, and religious hegemony, but they tightly hold on to the desire for our infinite Matrix shared by the myriad species through all time.

Preoedipal language is not repressed by the Father's grammar. Because there is an oceanic surge to unite with That One, there are strong tides and equally strong ebbs in the language of the gurus. When Guru Nanak utters "Ikk Oan Kar" a whole flow of waves comes rushing forth: "Truth by name primal creator without fear without enmity timeless in form unborn self-existent the grace of the Guru. . . ."

This has come to be known as the *mul mantra* or quintessential formula of the Sikh religion. During the Khalsa initiation it is repeated five times. The tenth guru fully understood and felt what Nanak uttered, and with the same momentum utters: "You have no trait, no trace whatsoever, No color, caste, or family. / How to describe Your features or complexion, the lines on Your palms or Your garb? / You are called eternal, self-illuminated, of infinite power, / Supreme among countless deities, Ruler among rulers, / Guardian of the three worlds—gods, humans, and demons, tiny blades of grass, and towering forests all proclaim your infinity!"

This is the beginning of his Jaap, a natural expansion of Guru Nanak's Jap. Since the realities and processes of his predecessor's verse shaped his

feelings and his unconscious, the strong verbal ebbs and tides of the first guru's poetry pour into the tenth's receptacle. The Utterly Transcendent is ruler among rulers, guardian of the three worlds, and yet has no trait, no color, no caste, no family. The Other, totally infinite and formless, is the One the guru tries to imagine in the minutest details—even looking for the lines in the palms of the hands! From Nanak to Gobind, Sikh gurus acutely imagine and feel the One. In a rapid succession they arrest concrete images, and in an equally rapid succession, they let them go—the Divine is never reduced or immobilized in their verse. Simultaneously deeply intense and vastly expansive are their emotions.

In fact, no terms were used by Nanak: the numeral “1” designates the Divine. Fifteenth-century India abounded with eloquent terms and philosophically sophisticated concepts from Sanskrit, Arabic, Persian, and from the Dravidic languages. Nanak utters “Oan” after the numeral “1.” *Oan* is the primal vocalic syllable of the Indian languages. The elemental modality of language becomes Guru Gobind Singh's expression as well, for he calls the One “song of songs” (Jaap, verse 47); “the sound of sounds” (verse 48). In a recent work, André Padoux explains *nada* as the manifestation of the uni-verse: “that which expresses.”⁴⁵ Guru Gobind Singh shares this view, and admits that the infinity spoken of (*kahe*) by him is not solo; rather, it is in chorus with the entire universe including “tiny blades of grass and towering jungles.” The tenth guru's language, too, is not in the father's grammar; his is the maternal language shared by the terrestrial and celestial worlds, connecting each of us with our cosmos. Whereas the Sikh gurus hear the One as the totality of the sonic energy that cannot be accounted for grammatically, their interpreters, translators, and reciters reduce their language of plenitude to a male “he,” stifling the dynamic processes of their expression.

The geometric arc flying off Nanak's “Oan” is a dynamic gesture of motion and movement. The circle is not closed; it cannot be closed. Following the same pattern, Guru Gobind Singh's Jaap is left without a closure in 199 verses. He ceaselessly addresses the Infinite in plentiful ways. Like the rapid flow of oxygen, carbon, hydrogen, and nitrogen in our bodies, the guru generates an ensemble of paradoxes: *andkare-tejteje* (deep darkness-brilliant light); *khape-thape* (destroys-creates); *balanbalan-rankanrankan* (highest of the high-poorest of the poor); *ajanmai-subanmai* (unborn-most beautiful). His contradictory movements awaken us from the patriarchal stupor of linear language, and stretch our imagination. The paradoxes are set in unique and repetitious movements, measures both long and short, and words that are Persian, Arabic, Sanskrit, Braj, and Punjabi. The Jaap mentioned above is in the language of the body, which is never complete, never static; it never stops growing. In turn, hearing, reading, and reciting the verses of the Khalsa makes our heart beat faster, and in the literal sense, “quicken” the pulse of

our life. Produced from the Primal Womb, they affect our diverse bodies in diverse and profound ways.

The gurus' endless ways of relating with the Divine illuminate Irigaray's words that "woman's sex is not one" and open up a space where our own pleasures can unfold in a variety of ways. The sense of plenitude strips off patriarchal stratifications and blots out masculine identity as the norm for imaging the Transcendent. Over and over the gurus repeat that the Infinite cannot be fixed, immobilized, incarnated. In stanza 5 of the Jap, Guru Nanak says, "That One cannot be molded or made," and in the same tone Guru Gobind Singh says, "Cannot be contained in a chant. Cannot be reduced to an idol. Cannot be captured in an image. Ever the elixir of elixirs" (Jap, verse 177). Nothing verbal or solid or visual, neither male nor female, can encapsulate the One. Guru Gobind Singh's juxtaposition of the negative processes of "containing" "reducing" and "capturing" with the positive "Ever elixir of elixirs" pulls the Infinite into the realm of pleasure and expands it. Elixir is drunk, taken into our bodies, and as it rushes into our bloodstream it brings up the serotonin levels, opening up even more avenues of enjoyment. In the Sikh gurus' rejection of images and idols we recover their strong tendency to exorcise rigid symbols of male dominance. In his Swayyais Guru Gobind Singh specifically denounces the "wearing of phalluses around the neck" (Swayyai 10). In his Chaupai he says, "The fool has no clue of the Formless One: he calls Lord Shiva the Eternal One" (verse 16). Lord Shiva's generative organ, the *linga*, represents the eternal creator, and is worshipped by his devotees with milk, honey, and sandalpaste. The hymns of the Khalsa decenter such male symbols and uproot the monopoly of the phallus. Semiotic *bani* incites us to shed the weight and burden of solidified phallocratic chains around our necks—"the phallus dangling from the neck" (Swayyai 10)—so that our bodies are unleashed for multiple *jouis-sance* with the Infinite.

Absorbed by the body, the Elixir produces the emotions of love and heroism, which expand the self and stimulate intimacy with the Transcendent. Four times in his Jaap Guru Gobind Singh addresses the One lovingly, and boldly as *amritamrite* (Elixir of elixirs), evoking each time the primal image of Nanak sipping the bowl of *amrit* in the River Bein. So love and heroism are not antithetical approaches—the former is not chosen by the "peace-loving" Nanak or the latter by the "warrior guru." They are not contrary movements, for love is not a withdrawal and stepping back into one's own space, nor is heroism a charging and stepping ahead into another's space. And they are not bifurcated into either "feminine" or "masculine" characteristics. Both love and heroism are basic hormones essential to life. They flow out together from the primal Sikh experience in the River Bein, and they are both suffused in *bani*.

Semiotic *bani* is the voice of Love, and as we discerned, the very first scriptural reference identifies her as the language of “infinite love” (Jap, stanza 4). The Ultimate is love, and the way to unite with That is also love, and so the two forces coming from each side intersect. With spasmodic energy, Guru Gobind Singh’s Jaap invokes the Transcendent as the “embodi-ment of love” (Jaap, verse 26), as “the incarnation of love” (verse 55) as “the love of love” (verse 68). As verse 80 of Jaap says,

The embodiment of love
Extends to all lands, to every nook and cranny.

Guru Nanak’s “language of infinite love” is indeed Guru Gobind Singh’s “Body of Love” (*raga rupe*) that fills all space. There are no cracks or fissures in this Body, which is the source of all our bodies. The entire universe is the semiotic voice of her endless love, and all species play and enjoy themselves in the maternal lap of day and night. Nanak’s Jap and Gobind’s Jaap mingle, echo, and coincide as they place love into the very womb of language. The infinite body of Love—*preet preete* (Jaap, verse 68)—opens our bodies so that we revel together. “Devotees who win your affection, revel in your love” says Nanak (Jap, stanza 27), and the ambrosia that flows out from the crucible of love in the last stanza of Guru Nanak’s Jap is relished by Guru Gobind Singh’s “reveler of all” (Jaap, verse 77), whom he lovingly salutes as “enjoyer of all!” (verse 15). The hymns of the Khalsa are grounded in the powerful passion and intimacy between us and our Divine.

Guru Gobind Singh’s Swayyais rhythmically repeat that without love, all religious practices are ineffective. He goes off in all directions, using ceaseless similes to make the point that studies, ablutions, charities, rituals, and all ascetic activities like “subsisting on air, practicing celibacy,” are utterly worthless.

How futile to sit in contemplation, like a stork with both eyes closed.
While trying to bathe in the seven seas, we lose this world and the next . . .
I tell the truth, do listen to me, they alone who love, find the Beloved.
(Swayyai 9)

The guru appropriates love as the highest form of action. This final line in the above quatrain—“they alone who love, find the Beloved” (*jin prem kio tin hi prabh paio*)—resonates through the entire hymn. Whereas love expands us, rigorous physical and mental techniques or ritual practices to purify the body only confine us. They wall us in and separate us from relating with the beauty and diversity around us. Our bodies are not polluted; they do not need any ritual cleansing. They are so lovely naturally that they are all savored by the One—the *sarbam bhugta* (reveler of all). The Khalsa’s long hair grows from this basic premise, and so do all the other Ks. Love is passionate and takes

lovers to those depths of richness and fullness where there is freedom from all sorts of limitations and barriers. Love is the powerful maternal hormone, which dissolves the individual ego and opens our pores so wide that we savor the Other with an intensity and immensity that no father's language can ever record.

Feminist writers distinguish *his* form of love from *hers*. Cixous and Clement comment, "[H]e needs to love himself. But she launches forth; she seeks to love."⁴⁶ Their explosive expressions define "the motto of all phallogocentric speculation / specularization, the motto of every Teste" as "himself." This masculine narcissistic self-absorption that ends with the sight and glories of the individual ego is contrasted with the feminine takeoff that descends deeper to "where a voice that doesn't know itself is lost in the sea's churning."⁴⁷ The male gurus endorse the feminine modality of love in which *she seeks to love*. Indeed, hers is a courageous plunge into the vast and churning sea where all divisions and circumferences break apart: "[T]he Divine is completely saturated in us like the mother in her child" (GG, 672). Heroism for the gurus is the essential element of *her* love—it shatters the mirrors of narcissism, it breaks solid walls of fear, it stops all arteries from clogging with pride, prejudices, or threats. *Her* heroism launches love to flow freely within the self and from one body to the other to That One in all of us—male and female, brown, black, and white.

The Sikh gurus physiologically link heroism with love, making the emotion even more vigorous and forceful. The prelude to Sikh scripture features the Transcendent with no fear and no hatred: "*ikk oan kar sat nam karta purakh nir bhau nir vair*. . . . One Being is Truth by name primal creator without fear without enmity." In the same breath Guru Nanak links the creativity of the One with the virtue of fearlessness. We can even spot the birthing process in the verbal root (*kr*, "make"). But the male symbolic fails to see the Nanakian link between procreation and valor, and refuses to acknowledge the maternal substratum of the Transcendent One. Instead, Herculean muscle becomes the sole signifier. The One is never translated, never recognized as a She. With the word *nirbhau* (without fear) a strong male dictator standing far above *his* creation with nobody to answer to is fixed in the Sikh public memory. Life does not develop from the fear of Him standing out there, but from the love that She has for all of her creation. The cosmos is bodied forth in love and not in animosity (*nirvair*) toward any offspring. In the memorable scene from the epilogue to the Jap, the whole universe plays in the "lap of day and night, the male and female nurses." Once they come out of their mother's body, all the variegated and complex creatures freely and delightfully cradle themselves on the melodious body of night and day. Without rivalries and enmity, they are together nestled on *her* body. The first Sikh hymn constitutes a remarkably organic textual body in itself, for the

latent and hidden womb of its prologue proliferates into the open and spacious lap of its epilogue.

Guru Gobind Singh retains the nexus between love and heroism, and reminds us of Guru Nanak's vision that they are birthed alike from the maternal body. His verses are a flashback to the mother.

Wielder of weapons
Hurler of missiles
Knower of all
Mother of the cosmos.
(Jaap, verse 52)

The chivalrous actions of the Invincible One are rooted in the fecund mother. Destroyer and creator are both aspects of That One, and the count-less divine activities envisioned by the guru all rest in the maternal locus. In his hymn called Chaupai, Guru Gobind Singh says that "the countless bodies are an expansion of you, O creator" (verse 13). In the Jaap, too, he says, "You permeate everybody." The Divine is the "life of all lives, the breath of all breath" (Jaap, verse 143). Guru Gobind Singh's hymn resounds with the Divine as the very life, the very "breath[,] of all creation" (verse 117). Several times he exalts That One as "linked" with us—as though the entire universe were tied to the Creator with an umbilical cord. In the Nanakian modality, the tenth guru brings out the female puissance of the Transcendent, and he even salutes the "wielder of weapons" as the "Mother of the cosmos" in the very same breath. For the Sikh gurus heroism is embodied in the female figure, who is love and creativity.

From the first to the tenth, the gurus regard heroism very highly, and the Jap, the hymn of "peace and serenity," recited daily by the Khalsa during "the ambrosial hour" (*amrit vela*), is saturated with the presence of mighty heroes and heroines. Even at its outset Nanak mandates valor. Courageous chords are required to extol the One who transcends all threatening barriers. Semiotic voice does not belong to the weak and fearful: "Filled with might, we sing praise of the Might" (Jap, stanza 3). It is the "invincible heroes" who sing divine praise in the *karam khand*, and they are empowered from within. They do not seek power over others. In this fourth spiritual realm, then, a vast array of heroes and heroines live peacefully—without a hierarchy, without a division, without a leader, and without any sort of religious or gender biases.

That sphere with its language of valor, that sphere of equality and freedom, that sphere where mighty heroes and heroines reside, that sphere so close to the home of the Divine that the two realms of Action (*karam*) and Truth (*sach*) are located in the same thirty-seventh stanza of the Jap—it is the sphere Guru Gobind Singh aspired to make into a social and political reality. The heroes and heroines conceived in Guru Nanak's *karam khand*

were delivered on Baisakhi 1699. Masculine rhetorics of rupture between the first and the tenth gurus have only fractured the Sikh psyche, leading Sikhs astray from the forceful confluence of their gurus. We recover an amazing continuity between them: Guru Gobind Singh wanted his contemporaries—reduced to weakness and passivity under political hegemony—to become like the citizens of Guru Nanak's *karam khand* who are “drenched” with the Divine. Clearly their might is the force of love. The gurus are in total consonance, for Arjan also defines valorous heroes as all those “who are colored by the love of the Divine in this very world” (GG, 679). Both men and women are clearly regarded as members of this heroic community, which lies not elsewhere but within the daily rhythms of our life on the lap of Mother Earth. In fact, we specifically heard Guru Nanak mentioning Sita and her peers as denizens of the *karam khand*. Though commentators may try to congeal her, Sita is definitely not “ice.” Nor is she a man “utterly sewn in devotion.” Nor is she a goddess whose body is immobilized into stone. For the Sikh gurus, Sita and women like her are real flesh-and-blood heroines residing in Guru Nanak's *karam khand*. To end political and social oppression, Guru Gobind Singh's Khalsa has to be heroic like them. Both men and women have to be courageous. For the birth of the Khalsa and for the reproduction of the Khalsa, the language of *karam khand* was necessary. So the tenth guru, inspired by the semiotic *bani* of his predecessors, uttered his words with great speed and velocity. His meters, his images, and his emotions come with spasmodic force, and when properly felt and applied, they shatter all symbolic hegemonies. The verses of the Khalsa can dispel cowardice and infuse the reciter with love and heroism, and we must welcome and acclaim them as such.

Indeed, they can charge us to live confidently and courageously without being scared to hold back love and creativity. Heroism is not muscle and power over others, but the powerful and healthy flow of creative liquids, which promote a healthy body, and love for our family, friends, nature, and our Creator by whom we are all birthed. Heroism incites us to contest sexism, racism, casteism, and classism. Heroism incites us to courageously discard narcissism, phobias, fears, and hatred. It is necessary that we boldly shatter all impediments that repress physical conception, artistic and literary productions, fulfilling social relations, and a true enchantment with the Divine. Thus, we passionately love the Infinite and revel in countless pleasures. That is the energy derived by tasting, seeing, hearing, reciting, and remembering the semiotic voice of the gurus.

Love and heroism come directly from the mother. The way we develop our notion of selfhood and relate with the world is contingent on our primal relationship with our mother. In his Jaap, Guru Gobind Singh extols the One in numerous ways, but the various functions and associations nestle on “the

Mother of the cosmos" (*lok mata*). Even in the hymn of Chaupai when Guru Gobind Singh solicits the Transcendent to crush his enemies in order to save and protect his Sikhs, we see him reaching out to a mother figure. Although he does not follow the rules and laws of grammar that would specify gender, a female Subject seems to materialize and linger in his imagination. She is present in the opening itself: "Give me your hand and protect me (*hamari karo hath de racha*)" (Chaupai, verse 1), and continues to prevail as we hear him implore through the entire hymn: "protect me with your own hands" (Chaupai, verse 5), "we seek your lap" (verse 21), "I seek your lap" (verse 24) "give me your hand and support me" (verse 25). The valiant guru constantly desires the physical sustenance and contact that is primally given by the mother. Strong female impressions, unrecognized in the father's symbolic, permeate Guru Gobind Singh's aesthetic *Weltanschauung*. We must attune ourselves so that in the sound of Guru Gobind Singh's heroic meters we can hear *her* life-giving breath, in his battle scenes we can see *her* creative space, in the dramatic movements of his weapons we can feel *her* nurturing hand, and in our daily activities and occupations we can sense *her* strength and support. We cannot let phallocratic memories obliterate our maternal link with the Transcendent established by the gurus.

The mother is explicitly addressed in Guru Amar Das's hymn called Anand, which forms the finale of the Khalsa initiation. Actually, all Sikh rites and ceremonies conclude with the recitation of six stanzas from the Anand by the entire congregation in unison. The same six stanzas here have also been incorporated into the evening prayer Rahiras, so before going to sleep, Sikh men and women enter into this primal mother-child relationship. Anand, meaning "bliss," opens with the lines:

My Mother! I am in bliss, for I have found my true guru;
My true guru I found so easily, my mind rings with felicitations!

The guru is in bliss, for he has found the true enlightener within himself. In his ecstasy we see him trying to seize the mother, *meri mae* (my mother)!

This vocative for the mother flows vibrantly in the Guru Granth. Coming from the lips of male poets, it is a verbal embrace gushing from the point closest to their unconscious. They ask of her passionate questions: "How can I live without the Name, O my mother?" (GG, 226); "How could I forget That, O my mother?" (349) "How do I unite with Truth O my mother?" (661); "What virtues will unite me with my life, O my mother?" (204). While they seek her knowledge, they also share passionate moments with her: "I am in love O my mother!" Each time the mother carries their language forward, making their experience come out alive. This is not a dual-istic opposition between *the male gurus vs. her*, but, to use Mikhail Bakhtin's

term, a “dialogic” relation that is rooted in openness and leads to a deeper self-awareness, to a deeper communion.

Clearly, it is not in opposition to but pulling toward the mother that Sikh gurus establish their identity. Since It is all space and time, that One of course has no gender, but when That One is felt, it is experienced as *both* father and mother. “You are my father and you are my mother!” exclaims Guru Arjan (GG, 103). Attaining divine bliss is like “the heart blossoming when it beholds the mother” (164). In the Sikh communal memory, however, the paternal relationship is retained and underscored, while the idyllic mother-child dyad is cast away.

To our ears the semiotic verses of the male gurus resonate with the views of feminist theologians and object-relations psychoanalysts who posit the maternal-infant relationship at the heart of a person’s psychological and social development. Instead of the Freudian oedipal conflict, castration complex, and individuality, feminist theologians like Naomi Goldenberg and object-relations psychoanalysts like Melanie Klein and D. W. Winnicott shift the focus to the maternal-infant relationship. Both theology and object-relations theory “derive their insights into the matrices that support human life from an image of a woman-in-the-past.”⁴⁸ The semiotic language of the gurus displaces the father from his dominating symbolic and cherishes the love of the mother, the care of the mother, the caresses of the mother, the transverbal communion with the mother. The male gurus seriously remember her prebirth and postbirth creativity, and our re-memories in turn can help us improve the individual and social fabric of our lives. “Just as the mother takes care of her children, so the One sustains us” (GG, 680). The abundant joy of envisioning the Ultimate is “like the look between a child and its mother” (452). When we feel the divine arms around us—“like a mother tightly hugs her child” (629)—we cannot but recharge the innermost batteries of our own selves, and renew our relationships with our families, friends, and community.

So it is *with* the mother that Sikhs wind up each day, each ceremony, and every rite of passage. The fifth and final liturgical hymn of the Khalsa culminating all Sikh rites, Anand, starts out by addressing the mother as the source of wondrous experience. Guru Amar Das says “mind-and-heart ring with felicitations (*manu vajia vadhaian*)!” (Anand, stanza 1). This joyous space sparkles and glitters with the precious jewels of wisdom that flashed out in the first hymn—“wisdom comprises jewels, gems, and pearls” (Jap, stanza 6). He attains his enlightenment “very easily” without having to go through any rigorous techniques or disciplines. As the stanza proceeds, “jewel-like melodies with their families and fairies from afar have come to sing the Word within me” (Anand, stanza 1). Fairies who belong to the world of the unconscious add to the horizon of his female imaginary. This is not a male *logos* that is grammatically structured. Here is excitement and joy, and there are no

defense mechanisms on his part. The guru is free, he is ecstatic. He hears beautiful music, and his body is sonorous with five instruments playing the Word. In a libidinal drive, his entire self reverberates with melodious rhythms. The guru merges oceanically with the world that we learn from her while we are still in her body.

That True Name is my sole support, satisfying all my hungers.
With peace and joy, it enters my mind, fulfilling all my desires.
(Anand, stanza 4)

The poet's sole support, that true name (*sach nam*), feeds him, satiates him, gives him peace and comfort, and fills him with joy.

Because the mother's milk is nurturing, "all hungers are satisfied." Sikh semiotic poetry flows with mother's milk. In our re-memory we see the food of the hostess (*bhadarani*) overflowing with the food of the mother, just as we hear the language of the guru joining in with the words of Cixous, "Voice: milk that could go on forever. Found again. The lost mother/bitter-lost. Eternity: is voice mixed with milk."⁴⁹ Sikh hymns remind us that every individual is formed from the physical and psychological sustenance provided by the mother. Her milk is inexhaustible. Not only does she feed her fetus with her nutrients, but also suckles the newborn with her life-giving milk. "The child's original attraction is to the mother's breast milk," acknowledges Guru Nanak (GG, 972). The fifth guru recalls the experience of "her milk poured into the baby's mouth" (987), and claims that satisfaction and fulfillment come from the mother pouring milk into her child's mouth (1266). The gurus compare the intensity of saintly devotion to that of an infant's love for the mother's milk (613). In an unforgettable juxtaposition of analogies, the Divine is like a "cane for the blind" and "like mother's milk for the child" (679). In another tender passage we read: "Says Nanak, the child, you are my father and my mother, and your name is like milk in my mouth" (713). Throughout the Guru Granth, the Sikh gurus unabashedly express their attachment to the Divine through an infant's attachment to the mother's breast: "[M]y mind loves the Divine, O my life, like a child loves suckling milk" (538).

These scriptural images of the delicious and invigorating milk pouring into the mouth flow into the musical melodies and rhythms that Guru Amar Das sensuously registers in his Anand. Paradoxically, however, his music is played to *anahad*—the "soundless sound" "the unstruck melody"! This subtle, self-producing sound, or what is called "unstruck sound," vibrates constantly in our universe. Though within each and every body, it cannot be heard through the father's rational methods, but only through the mother's elemental consciousness. There is no linear discourse here by the guru to prove his supreme enlightenment. He experiences total unicity in which he lyrically

and polymorphously delights. The semiotic verses of the Khalsa reverberate with “the primal source (*dhuri ki bani*),” the mother, who in Cixous’s words “nourishes, and who stands up against separation; a force that will not be cut off but will knock the wind out of the codes.”⁵⁰ The oral is the aural, and the milk that is drunk is no different from the *bani* that is heard: “[A]s milk quenches the child, ambrosial *bani* quenches all heat” (GG, 978). *Amrit* sipped in the River Bein, *amrit* prepared by Guru Gobind Singh in Anandpur, and *amrit* recited by the Sikhs daily in Punjab or New York overflow from the maternal surplus. In a plurality of sounds and rhythms, in a collage of artistic images, semiotic *bani* replays Guru Nanak’s effervescent mnemonic, “[T]hat One is the calf, She is the cow, and She is the milk” (1190). The hymns of the Khalsa are intrinsically written in “white ink,” and we need to absorb the maternal element in order to derive total nutrition and full benefit.

And so the True Name (*Ikk Oan Kar Sat Nam*) uttered by Guru Nanak in his Jap, the Mother of the cosmos extolled by Guru Gobind Singh in his Jaap, the Beloved envisioned by Guru Gobind Singh in his Swayyais, the hands and lap desired by him in his Chaupai, are poetically carried over into the Anand and merge into the body of the mother. The five hymns of the Khalsa are a flashback to the mother whose body is imprinted on the deepest memory. They serve as a reentry into the innermost core of ourselves—returning the reciter and hearer to the original source of wisdom and joy underlying all our conscious powers. There is an ultimate depth to our life below the plane of fatherly thinking and reasoning. Semiotic *bani* takes us away from a logical world where we are divided into subject and object, male and female; it brings us back to the semiconscious self where dualisms begin to dissolve, to the unconscious where we do not feel or imagine anything, to the ultimate experience of total Oneness (*Ikk Oan Kar*). We return to our primordial mother who is all, not divided into male or female. This is the abundant unity that the Sikh gurus were deeply aware of and thoroughly savored.

In turn our re-memories of the oceanic experience in her body and of her strength, wisdom, and snuggles melt away our splintered and patriarchal individuality. They replenish us with a new identity, which Guru Gobind Singh birthed on that historic Baisakhi celebration day by the banks of the Sutlej. Social, political, and religious divisions could only be eliminated by a new subjectivity suckled from the maternal *amrit* semiotically produced. Since they integrate the interior and exterior of Sikhs with the mother’s patterns of love and plenitude, the five *banis* that Guru Gobind Singh gave his newly born Khalsa match perfectly with the five *Ks* in which he dressed them up. The once-in-a-lifetime rite of passage of the Sikhs and their daily routine tellingly endorse Naomi Goldenberg’s feminist thesis that “Plato has it back-wards; the search for the wholly transcendent is, historically and psychologically, the search for the remembered state of union with the wholly

immanent.”⁵¹ The body of the Transcendent, circulating in the body of the gurus, is the body of *jouissance*. Sikh ontology, history, and aesthetics come together in the maternal experience of infinity—within the *body* of every Sikh, male and female alike.